Check your skin once a month.

Skin cancer happens on **every** skin tone. Found early, most are curable. Here is how to look, in about 10 minutes.

The 10-minute skin check

1. Stand in good light with a full-length mirror and a hand mirror. Ask a family member to help.
2. Face, ears, lips, and inside your mouth. Part your hair and check your scalp.
3. Neck, chest, and belly. Women: lift the breasts and check underneath.
4. Arms, underarms, and both sides of your hands. **Look at your palms and between your fingers.**
5. **Fingernails and toenails.** Look for a new dark line or band in a nail.
6. Back, buttocks, and the backs of your legs, using the hand mirror or a helper.
7. Front of your legs, then your feet. **Check the soles, your heels, and between your toes.**
8. Write down anything new. Take a phone photo to compare next month.

See a doctor about a spot that is:

- **New**, and you have not seen it before
- **Changing** in size, shape, or color
- **Bleeding**, itching, or crusting
- **Not healing** after 3 to 4 weeks
- **A new dark line in a nail**, especially if it gets wider or the skin next to the nail turns dark
- **Different** from all your other spots (the "ugly duckling")

A spot does not have to hurt to be serious.

The spots people miss

On Black, brown, and Asian skin, melanoma is often found on the **palms, soles, between the toes, and under the nails**, places that get little sun and that people rarely check. Look there every month.

What to look for on your skin.

Warning signs do not always look "red" or "pink." The same problem can look different on different skin.

Lighter skin

Melanoma: a brown or black spot with uneven edges or more than one color.

Other skin cancers: a pink, pearly bump; a rough, scaly patch; a sore that will not heal.

Medium skin

Melanoma: a dark brown or black spot that is growing or changing, often on hands, feet, or nails.

Other skin cancers: a brown, tan, or shiny bump; a scaly patch darker than the skin around it.

Darker skin

Melanoma: a very dark, black, or even purple or pink spot on a palm, sole, or under a nail; a new dark band in a nail.

Other skin cancers: a dark, shiny bump, or a sore that will not heal, often in an old scar or burn.

The ABCDEs of melanoma

- **A**symmetry: one half does not match the other
- **B**order: edges are ragged, blurred, or uneven
- **C**olor: more than one color, or a color that is changing
- **D**iameter: bigger than a pencil eraser (but can be smaller)
- **E**volving: changing in size, shape, color, or feel

What raises your risk

- Past sunburns, years of sun, or tanning beds
- Age over 50, or a family member with melanoma
- Many moles, or a spot already treated
- A weak immune system, or an old scar, burn, or sore

Where to get it looked at

- **Your doctor** or a dermatologist. Medicare and most insurance cover a visit for a worrying spot.
- **No insurance?** Community health centers see everyone, on a sliding fee: **findahealthcenter.hrsa.gov**
- **Free skin checks: aad.org/spotme** (American Academy of Dermatology)

Questions? everyshadescreening@gmail.com · (915) 400-7072

Free monthly self-check guide with reminders: zainjaffar06.github.io/everyshade/check

Sources: American Academy of Dermatology; Skin Cancer Foundation; Culp and Lunsford, Prev Chronic Dis (CDC), 2019; Perlman et al., Int J Womens Dermatol, 2021. General health education only, not medical advice. Our members are students, not medical professionals.